

The Need for Saṅgha, Community and Questions about Ordinary Daily Life

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Dharma Talks · 50:05

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sama Sambuddhasa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sama Sambuddhasa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sama Sambuddhasa — Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and fully self-awakened one.

I just want to say a few words about *Saṅgha*. The word *Saṅgha* is traditionally, or in the East anyway, only refers to the monastic orders, the monks and the nuns. But in the West, it's become a self-referential word, where Buddhists refer to themselves as the Saṅgha. So it also has been widened out to include everybody. And that shows the effect of the secularization of Buddhism and the role of lay people.

But I just want to take you back to the beginning to show you how it began. So when the Buddha decided that he would teach — there was some doubt in his mind over the subtlety of the teaching, who knows — but anyway he went back to his companions and the first two talks where he introduces his teaching, it seems all of them became fully liberated.

We have to presume that they'd done a lot of work beforehand, like he had. I mean, he'd done all the practices of concentration, practices of self-mortification, which he didn't gain much from, apart from suffering. And then, of course, he went off by himself, and his search turned around upon itself. So instead of seeking happiness, he began to investigate how he was causing suffering. And it was that that led him to his awakening. And that's why we say he self-awakened.

There was lots of practice at that time. Lots of men, mainly men, but also some women, who were leaving society and living as *salmoners*, as the homeless ones. So it wasn't that he started a tradition. It had been long there. Within that society it was all part of a great movement in that society. Politically there was a movement away from tribal governance where you had elders and you had a chief elder — so that was like the Buddha's father of the Sakya tribe — and then it was moving towards monarchy. So actually the Sakyans, this little group of people just on the edge of Nepal, under the Himalayas, were under the local king of Kosala. That would have been Pasenadi at that time. So they were vassals. In other words, the system was becoming what we would recognize as medieval.

So when he began to teach, certain people, men at first, but then women, wanted to join him. And we call it the first ordination. He just said, *ehi passico*, which means come and try.

There's a story about him rejecting women for the order, which I'm sure you've come across, where these

court ladies, his stepmother — can't remember who else — they came to join the order and to prove that they were up to the raw life of the monastic order. You know, where you just live out in the forest, really, without any of the commodities of life. And when he came to them, he didn't think they'd make it. So he denies entry. And it's only when Ananda says to him, do you think women can become liberated? And he says, yes. And so he accepts them.

But there's definitely little tales in the scriptures that he was accepting women long before that. So this is really, I suppose, the growth of, well, the effect of patriarchy on society, even on the order.

So he was accepting people, and then once he had a group of men and women who were fully liberated, the ordination procedure was to take refuge in him as the teacher, as the living embodiment of the Dharma, the teaching he was giving, and then the Sangha, which were these people who had intuited *Nibbāna* at some level, and some of them were fully liberated. And that's become the lay ordination now. So when somebody wants to join the Buddhist religion, the Buddhist faith or whatever, you would go through a little ceremony.

But then of course after about 20 years there were men and women who joined who weren't quite at the usual standard and were doing terrible and naughty things. So they had to establish rules. And it shows that he was very much a pragmatist. He didn't have some ideal as to where he wanted the order to be. The rules came as the monks and nuns did something which was considered to be not right, not correct.

Some of them were like thieving, any sexual intercourse. All that was — I mean, monks made that mistake. And the first monk was, he didn't have the penalty of being kicked out of the order. And then it goes all the way down to having things you shouldn't have. And so there are ceremonies where you give it up, where you have to hand it back, things like that. So you've got 227 of these rules and many more, which were created as the order went along.

So when you look at them, they're sectioned out in order of seriousness. But they're all higgledy-piggledy, and some of them don't pertain anymore, like not to sit on woolen rugs. So presumably wool in those days was something quite precious.

So the ordination then became quite complicated. People were joining because they were in debt to the government. So you couldn't join if you were in debt. There was a physician called Jivaka, who was very famous at the time, who offered his medical services free to order members. So sick men and women joined the order in order to get this free. That sounds pretty straightforward, doesn't it? So you can't join the order if you're sick.

Now that's not an absolute rule. If you join a particular group of monks or nuns, they can decide to accept you. But if they think your illness is not going to undermine them financially or physically, you have to look after people. But once you're in, then really you have to be looked after. There's no way. And of course they didn't do that at that time sometimes.

And when the Buddha came across somebody who was really sick and because it was diarrhoea and vomiting and all that, nobody wanted to treat him. So he did it. He did it with an anger. And then he turns to the monks and says, well, you know, you haven't got a mother and father who's going to look after you if you don't look after people. He berated them that way.

So you have the order. Now, the order in the East still fills a real role. Virtually all meditation teachers are monks and nuns. You do get lay people, but it's almost considered an encroachment on the monk's role. The people who know about the Dharma, who study the Dharma, and who teach the Dharma, are, for the most part, monks and nuns. And the ones who live by way of that relationship of alms taking are the monks and nuns.

Now, the Buddha wanted that relationship, so I'm coming back to this whole idea about relationship, about interdependence, about love. He didn't want the monks and nuns to be self-supportive. He wanted them to continue to be alms takers, to be dependent on lay people for their well-being, for everything they have, to be dependent on lay people. And what was the other side of the gift was that lay people would go to the monks for spiritual advice, for spiritual teachings. So there was that economy of generosity. The one gave to the other as and when was needed.

And of course, there's this whole idea of *kamma* that by giving, by generosity, you accumulate goodness power. Now, I know that many people in the East do conceptualize it into some sort of bank account so that when you die, you go to a beautiful heaven because you gave all this food to monks. But the basic psychology is correct because remember, whenever you're generous, you're giving something up that you could have used for yourself. Giving up some of your wealth, giving up some of your time. And to do that is renunciation.

So the process of liberation is the process of renunciation. Don't confuse that with self-mortification. Renunciation means letting go of attachments. So every time you give something, you're making a step towards your own liberation. And in the commentaries, it makes it clear that the process of generosity leads to liberation by way of renouncing what you would have used for your own personal satisfactions and joy, and giving it to somebody else.

So, as you do that, your goodness power, that's the proper translation of *puñña*, your goodness power grows. And that goodness power manifests in your growing desire to liberate yourself from suffering.

Now, we have a situation in the West, where, actually, some of the best teachers are lay people. And that most of the monks and nuns either can't teach or don't want to. Which is true also in the East. It's not as though just because you become a monastic you're going to be a great teacher. Far from it. And you might not want to. There's other roles you can play within the order. And you might not want to anyway. You don't have to play a role.

When it comes to academics, the understanding of the scriptures and whatnot, there's massive, brilliant

work being done by academics. Some of the best books on Buddhism now, written by people who are PhDs, etc., etc. They're not monks at all. They don't belong to a monastic order.

So, two of these major roles that are played by monastics in the East, of being the teachers of the actual practice and the teachers of the teaching, of the actual teaching of the Buddha, has been, as you were, taken away by lay people. So now there comes a real problem. Why do you want to support a monk? Since the economy of generosity has now disappeared. I'm still dependent on you, but you're no longer dependent on me. So there's something undermining that interdependency. There was a fair swap there. You fed me and I told you how to practice *vipassanā*. Now, let's be careful because this comes a bit like a business deal.

So what would you think might be other reasons why you might support a monastic?

Now, if you take a Christian position, the monastic orders, beginning with Benedictine, had to look after themselves. So they separated out of society. This meant that there was a cleavage. The monks were way over there up in the hills having a great time and we were down here. But we didn't have to support them, and they didn't have to teach us. They're fine. But the belief was, of course, that they're doing a lot of prayer, and especially these enclosed orders, they're praying for the world, and there's a belief that that is doing good.

Then you get this amazing saint, Saint Francis. When I saw his patchwork robe made out of sackcloth, that was quite a little moment for me. So here was a man and the people who followed him, out of St. Claire, who went right back to that absolute poverty and depended upon lay people for their well-being. Although the early friars could work. They could do work and get money for it, labor. And the connection there between friars and the lay people was immediate.

So, coming back to the Buddhist order in the West, there is this bit of a problem, you see. And especially if Western people haven't really taken on the idea of building up a little piggy bank so you get to a better place when you die. Most people are very iffy about that. First of all, the whole idea of a bank account and the whole idea that you're going to go anywhere after death is very iffy. I mean, you know. Supposedly you don't. And I've given all this stuff away. I mean, that's fair.

So there's a whole area here of having to relocate, of having to find some reason as to why a lay person might support a monastic. Now when the order went to China, you see, beggars looked down upon you. You could not beg. So a famous abbot, whose name I forget of course, said, no work, no food. So in China, the monks began to grow their own food.

And there's a lovely little film called *White Clouds*, something *White Clouds*, where this American has gone to China and he's gotten to know these Buddhist monks way up in the hills, who knows where they are. And there they are, they're planting their own little crops and living secluded lives up in the hills. And every so often they come down into the village to collect stuff. I don't know whether they receive it by

generosity or not.

So you can see that the order had to change there in terms of looking after itself, really. But in so doing, lost its connection with lay people. There wasn't that exchange anymore of generosity.

So, why would you want to support me if I didn't teach? If you knew that I was just in this little hut in the middle of Wales, messing about, doing a bit of meditation, reading, and I turn up at your doorstep with a bowl. What would you say? What do you want? What's this about?

And that often happened. It happened to the Buddha. Some Brahmin really berated him and said, you know, you're useless. You don't do anything. You come here and you're begging for food. Who the hell are you? And the Buddha said, well, thank you for the present. I offer it back to you. So he went on his way. So it wasn't as though everywhere Buddhist monks they were, they were thought to be worthy of donation.

So I'd like to offer you one reason why you should support me in my little hut up in the Brecon Beacons in the middle of winter. If you look upon a monastery as a spiritual hospital — so your body can be diseased and we're very happy to help people overcome physical diseases, we have no problem with that. There are mental illnesses. And we're very happy to help people who we see are mentally disturbed and need help.

So now, there are spiritual diseases. And by which I mean those people who are longing for liberation from suffering. Who actually feel their suffering strong enough whereby life as we generally know it has become meaningless. Right?

So one of the signs of somebody who's moving towards a spiritual life is to realize the meaninglessness of life. What's the point of living? I mean, here we are, we've been born. We haven't a clue where we're going. We fill our lives with doing. We give ourselves a sense of purpose by doing something for others because others say how wonderful we are. And looking back in the old comedian saying, life's hard and then you die. See?

So, meaninglessness. Like life, it's an existential crisis that we may come across where we find that there's no reason for living. There's no reason for our lives. Because in the end, you disappear, you die. That's the end of it. So that sense of meaninglessness moves towards despair. It moves towards the existentialist philosophers like Albert Camus who felt that, well, you know, we've got life. Evening can be merry because tomorrow you die. That's the end of that.

So people in the West who normally turn up with a spiritual disease have come across this emptiness. Emptiness meaning meaninglessness of their lives. And somehow there's something in them which says, well, I don't believe it. I don't believe that life is purposeless, that there is something, that there is some purpose in it. And the purpose cannot be out there. The purpose cannot be out there because at some point I'm going to have to turn into myself and die. So the purpose must be within me somewhere. And that's your spiritual search.

So that's the Buddha, you see. The Buddha is living in an age where the obsession was rebirth — constant rebirth, how to get out of this constant rebirth. You know, if you did something wrong you might be reborn as a dog and then the next life you're born as a human being and the next life you're born into a happy realm then you fall from that and you come back as a human being. So one of the terrors of the age was this idea that you'd be constantly reborn. How could you get out of that in any permanent way?

And there were a few people believed in, you know, were materialists. They believed that when you die, that's the end of it. There was also that belief going on. But there was also this search for something which was beyond this constant *samsāra*, this constant onward going.

And so when he left on his search, he would have been in that state of meaninglessness. He would have also been in a state of existential crisis. And it manifests in the tale, the legend of him seeing somebody sick, somebody old, somebody dying, somebody dead, a corpse, and somebody sitting under a tree, a *śalm* *oner*, a mendicant sitting under a tree. And all the time it's put in this mythological way that he asks, you know, what is this? He's never seen this sort of thing before.

Does it happen to me? Yes. Sickness, aging and death. And then the possibility of some sort of answer. So that's what really a monastery is about. Or a collection of people who gather together for spiritual purpose is to find what reason there is for living, for being alive. And worse, what's the reason for dying? Is there a purpose in our death?

So I hope you continue to put some money in the box so that eventually I can escape to the Brecon Beacons in my little hut, knowing full well that there's always going to be a plate of spaghetti for me when I get down the hill.

So now, coming back on that, we have this whole idea of *Saṅgha*, community. This is, of course, really weighted in all religious traditions, not only religious traditions, humanistic traditions, any tradition. And there's a lovely little saying here when the Buddha says, in the discourse, which is the last moments of his life before he dies, and he says to Ānanda that he feels happy because he's established the four congregations. The monks, the nuns, the lay women and the lay men. And he felt that they were now rooted well enough that they would continue with the teachings after he died.

And when Ānanda says to him at this point, he says, well, the whole of the spiritual life, as far as he's concerned, this is Ānanda talking to the Buddha. He says he feels that half the spiritual life is good companionship, admirable friendship, admirable camaraderie. And the Buddha says, "Oh no, Ānanda. It's the whole of the spiritual life. The whole of the spiritual life is this interdependency." It's the whole idea that you're not on your own and that you do need other people. It's not just the other teacher. You need other people to support you in your practice.

That's why we come together here now. We formed a sangha and we're helping each other. There's no need to speak. There's no need to talk. It's something that's happening within us and yet it's so easy for us.

It's much easier, shall I say, for us when we know that everybody else in the room is also suffering. It's much easier to sit here with all this pain and horror, knowing that somebody else right next door to me, sitting right here, is probably going through worse. Mind you, we normally think that they're having a great time. You come in here and everybody's sitting like this, and you think, "Oh my goodness."

So that's the accent the Buddha puts on friendship when it comes to the spiritual life. And if you consider now, if you were a Muslim living in somewhere like Saudi Arabia, and you just wanted to follow those five times a day when you wanted to pray. And right there, in the middle of your coffee break, you got your mat out and off you went. And everybody thought, "Oh, that's a good idea." And they all joined you. Can you imagine doing that in London? Or in Dublin. Imagine getting your mat out in the middle of a work pit, in the middle of a factory, or a workplace, and just saying, "Well, I'm just going to do my prayers now."

So you can see that to live in a society which has lost that general grounding for the spiritual life, it makes it just that much more difficult for us. Just when we want to maintain mindfulness, when we want not to go out and get drunk, et cetera, et cetera, and party and all that, you're considered unsociable. Part of our behavior becomes unsociable because we're not actually joining in the regular behavior of people who don't really have any spiritual vein in their lives. They don't quite know where they're going with that. All their practices is within their work. And it might be good work, too. It's not as though work itself is undermined because your good work is undermined because you don't believe in a spiritual life, far from it. But you can see that because you don't have that immediate companionship, your practice is constantly undermined by the surroundings you're in. So it means you have to work a bit harder.

Now, going back to friendship, just to quote another quote that the Buddha says: "With regard to external factors, I don't envisage any other single factor like admirable friendship as doing so much for someone in training who has not attained the heart's goal but remains intent on the unsurpassable safety from bondage. Someone who is a friend with admirable people abandons what is unskillful and develops what is skillful." I mean, that's the point of a friend. They will support you when you're being skillful and not support you when you're being unskillful. And therefore, you get that support.

When you read the scriptures, by the way, I mean, I've translated it as somebody. It's always monk. But the commentaries tell us that this stands for anybody who's listening to the Dharma. It's like the phrase, "all hands on deck." What is it, a synecdoche? Come on, where's your school?

And when it comes to the lay people, there are a few discourses where the Buddha's explaining how we ought to live. And here he is talking to lay people. And what is meant by admirable friendship? This is the case where the lay person, in whatever town or village he may dwell, spends time with householders and householders' sons, young or old, who are advanced in virtue. He talks with them, engages them in discussions. He emulates consummate conviction in those who are consummate in conviction, consummate virtue in those who are consummate in virtue, consummate generosity in those who are consummate in generosity, and he emulates those who are consummate in discernment. He emulates

discernment in those who are consummate in discernment. This is called admirable friendship. In other words, seeking people out who have these virtues. Generosity, faith, virtue and discernment. Those who have confidence.

To be with people who have confidence fills you with confidence. To be with people who are generous makes you want to be generous. To be with people who are virtuous, you naturally want to be virtuous like them. And people who are wise, you tend to listen to them. So there's his description of good friendship.

But then he goes on. In another passage he says what good friendship is. It inspires love. Good friendship inspires love. It inspires respect. Good friendship inspires respect. It inspires emulation. Good friendship inspires emulation. A good friend listens. A good friend listens. And a good friend gives good advice. A good friend gives good advice. A good friend is able to enter into deep issues with the other. Enter into deep issues. And a good friend helps you not waste your resources—waste your money, waste your time. So here's a description of a good friend.

But he goes on even further. He says, "A friend gives what is hard to give." That's the test, isn't it? A friend gives what is hard to give. So you know your friends immediately. "He does what is hard to do." A friend does what is hard to do. "A friend has patience with harsh speech and has patience with wrongdoing." So if you love somebody, you have to presume they're going to hurt you. If you love somebody and you think they're never going to hurt you, then you're going to be very upset when they do.

So if you presume that your friend, your family member, at some point will do something which is painful for you at whatever level, then you can easily forgive them and re-establish friendship. But if you think they shouldn't do that, if you think that a friend or a family member should not behave like that towards me, then that's it. You've cut off friendship. That's it. That's the end of it. Take them to court.

A good friendship is someone whom you can confide in and someone who keeps your confidences. Someone you can confide in and somebody who keeps your confidences. That's a very deep trust, depending on what it is you're sharing. And often it's very helpful to talk to somebody, to talk out a problem. It can be relieving to the heart to share a burden with somebody. But you wouldn't do it if you thought they'd be off and tell the very person whom you're complaining about.

"And free of contempt." Free of contempt. Somebody who does not despise you. Somebody who may envy you but does not act upon it. Somebody who may feel an occasional jealousy but does not act upon it. So these are good pointers, aren't they? Don't you think so? I rather like them. It points out the difficulty of friendship.

So, sometimes we get the impression that Buddhism is really all about *vipassanā* and meditation and basically that's what it is. And then we forget that there is a whole eightfold path, that the *vipassanā* belongs to the last three, right effort, right concentration, right mindfulness. But that feeds into the first

one, which is right understanding. But then once you've got right understanding, it has to become systemic. It has to manifest in our attitudes. And as soon as it begins to manifest in our attitudes, it must express itself. Right speech, right action, right livelihood. And the whole thing flows around upon itself. The one feeds upon the other. So it's a spiral. It keeps turning and turning. And in this way, within a small length of time, if we practice with severe dedication, we will no doubt be liberated.

So, I want to, before I end, I just want to have a look at these questions that I didn't answer yesterday, because they're more to do with the practice. I just want to leave a bit of time too for daily practice.

So, is it difficult for me to reconcile that a practicing Buddhist can be a non-vegetarian? I don't know of any Buddhist country where Buddhists don't eat meat, which doesn't tell you very much. It's a special practice of monks and nuns in Burma that they go through the three month season, the *vassa* season, the rainy season, without eating meat.

The essential problem is the suffering of animals, the killing of animals. And it depends upon your connection with that. Obviously when you're eating the meat you're not killing the animal. If anything you're suffering from greed. But you're definitely not suffering from aversion or hatred or anything like that. But it's making that connection really that when you buy something you're going back to support the abattoir, you're going back to support the killer of the animal. And so it's up to your own sensibility really as to where you feel you can place yourself in that order.

But in Buddhist understanding, all sentient beings suffer one way or the other. And so it's up to the individual to decide. Now, there are some people who actually have to eat meat. I know somebody who has, I think, something like half a kidney or something. And the only way they're going to survive is by... And the body won't accept pulses and stuff like that. It's by eating chicken. So, there is this view that if it's for health reasons, then you should feel okay about that.

And there, of course, are situations in the world. If you live in the Arctic, you're hardly going to grow wheat, are you? If you live in desert, you're going to eat a goat. What are you going to do? If you live in Wales, it's bad enough. Somebody wants you to keep sheep. What can you grow in Wales? If you're up on the Brecon Beacons, it's pretty deserted up there.

So, remember that the Buddha is very pragmatic. There's no ism. He wouldn't have agreed with vegetarianism. Because idealism doesn't fit in a world which is obviously relative. All our morality is relative, it's circumstantial. You can make a declaration of not to kill anybody, but I'm sure you can think of occasions when you'd have felt quite justified in killing somebody. Not to take what is not freely given. You remember the old thing that you get at school about, if you're dead hungry, can you steal a loaf? So once you realize that morality is circumstantial, it's all to do with the situation you're in.

You know that one about the... If I can remember it right now. You might have heard this. This is one of these silly thought experiments. You're on a bridge with a very, very big fat man. And there's a train

coming along. And there are people working on the tracks. And you can see that this train is going to hit these people. One way, about five or six people. But if you push the man off, it'll derail the train and save five people. Now, will you push him off? It's a dilemma, I hope. None of us have to face it. It's examples like that that show you that morality can be quite circumstantial.

So yes, it's up to a person to decide that. I have a meditator who comes quite often and she simply cannot eat pulses and beans. She just won't take it. So she normally brings sardines or something with her if she's on a week-long retreat. So there's also health reasons.

And of course, there is the understanding that nature feeds off itself. There's a YouTube. If you type in Yellowstone and you come up with Monbiot, who's this writer. Do you know who I'm talking about, Monbiot? He's not that well known. And he's very much into rewilding the old places. And the video shows you how the introduction of about twenty or thirty wolves completely changed the ecology of Yellowstone Park. I mean, right, now what's he introducing? He's introducing an animal that eats another animal. So you have to understand that nature feeds off itself. So really, it just comes back to us and our particular situation in this society where vegetarianism is very easy to get hold of. You can be a vegan without any problem if you want to.

Does it ever get easier with the meditation? No, that's an easy question. If you keep practicing over years, guess what? For me it seemed easier to meditate when I started. Now it seems harder after a few retreats. Dead on, because the main reason is that you're digging deeper. When you come to meditation you come with beginner's mind and you sit there and you're full of vigor and interest and then like anything else it gets boring. Who the hell wants to watch their breath? What's the daft thing to do anyway? And then there's... and then the stuff starts coming up. So that purification, you just can't get anywhere without going through it. Full stop. That's it. It's just part and parcel of the course.

But generally speaking, of course, you look back and you think, well, life's changed, my attitude has changed, life's just a little bit easier. But that doesn't mean to say it's going to be always like that, because you've got ups and downs. Spiritual life's like that. Sometimes you think you're getting nowhere. And then when that crisis passes, you find you've moved to a slightly different level. So don't give up hope. Not yet, anyway.

How to establish a daily meditation practice in your life. So, it really is, I think, important to meditate a little in the morning. And if you can, to do one in the evening, but especially when you come back from a day out or a day's work, before you eat. After you eat you fall asleep. The beginning of the day is when you set your weather then, where you actually remind yourself you want to maintain this level of awareness, affectionate awareness, to be awake to what's happening. And when you come back from a day, just to let whatever you've accumulated in that day just arise—little aversions, little irritations, little anxieties—just let them come up and clear themselves out. And then you have a much more

restful evening. On top of that, to stop everything a little bit before you go to sleep. There's no point in

launching yourself into bed after two hours on Facebook or having watched the latest crime drama and then thinking you're going to have deep sleep. Well, you may, of course, but generally speaking it's best to calm down. Play some music, read poetry, do something which brings the whole system down so when you fall asleep, you're taking that beauty, that beautiful mental state with you. That's how you feel more refreshed, I think.

There's no easy way to establish a daily practice. You've got to establish a real religious commitment. So you have to say to yourself, "Right, I can definitely do twenty minutes every morning. There's no reason why I can't do twenty minutes." If you can't think of that, then five minutes. And then you actually make that absolute determination that for the next six months that's what you're going to do. That's how you establish the practice.

If you do it, then you have to promise yourself something like a celebratory meal. And if you don't, you have to promise yourself, I don't know, jump off a bridge or something. Something terribly wild and terrible that would stop you, would keep you at your promise. But really that's the thing—to do it religiously for the length of time. Then it becomes an internal habit. You might miss a day, you might miss two days, but you don't want to miss more than that.

I remember Nureyev, the great ballet dancer of the sixties and seventies, said that if you didn't practice one day, it was fine. Two days, he felt it. Three days, everybody else did. So if you take that as your standard for practice, then really just keep at it. If you do miss it and you have to start again, just don't go into this self-hate syndrome—"I'm useless" and all that rubbish. Just start it again. It's important, because that's where you accumulate. This is your goodness. You accumulate the practice. It accumulates slowly.

"With so many varied Buddhist practices, is it best to self-teach using the original text, such as a combination of available books, audio, etc.?" Yeah, obviously listening intently to your audio—that's me, thank you.

In the first place, well, absolutely. No, I think it's important to get hold of a teacher. When I think of my introduction—I wouldn't... What happened to me was I read a book on Zen Buddhism. I was impressed by it, so what I did was, I thought, "I'm going to practice this." So I was on the way to the shops, which would have taken about five or seven minutes. I'm walking up the road, observing myself walking up the road. By the time I got to the top, I thought, "Oh, this is going to drive me crazy." So I abandoned Zen Buddhism.

Later on, through crisis and all sorts of stuff, I ended up with a Zen teacher in Birmingham. She came in and sat me on the bench facing a wall, told me to keep my eyes slightly open—dead man's eyes—gave me a punch in the back so I sat up properly. And then her instruction was, "Watch whatever comes up." That was it: watch whatever comes up. And that was forty minutes of sheer horror and pain and all that. But for some reason, at the end of that, I just knew this was going to get me out of the state I'd gotten myself into.

So without that, I think you've got to go somewhere. I think you need that personal contact. Even if it's only once in a while—it doesn't have to be something constant—but you need to have that personal contact from somebody whom you feel has been there. It's like if you climb a mountain, who are you going to get advice from—a geologist or a mountaineer?

"Buddhism involves considerable self-awareness and concentrated practice that many, for various reasons, are not in a position to do. Their mindset, mental health issues, etc. So, is it only for the select few?"

Well, it's true to say that *vipassanā* isn't good for somebody who's mentally ill. In the East, if you turn up at a monastery with an obvious sign of mental illness—depression or whatever—they just give you *mettā* practice. They don't give you *vipassanā*. But anybody who's in an ordinary state of madness can practice *vipassanā*. What's the problem? I mean, we're all, at one level or another, crazy.

That's why this mindfulness has been so successful, really. It's used as a psychotherapeutic intervention and therefore takes away its spiritual purpose. But for the occasional person, just those introductions, just that simple introduction, understanding how suffering is caused, may very well open the spiritual gates for them. Just because it's being taught as a psychotherapeutic intervention doesn't mean it might not have a spiritual effect on the person. It's not taught like that—generally speaking, it's not taught with any moral instructions with it. But of course there is a presumed morality in it of compassion.

Some Buddhist teachers are a bit negative about it, but I don't see a problem really. It's a bit like yoga—body beautiful. What's wrong with that? You miss out on all the rest of it, but at least you've got a beautiful body. That'll do.

"Is Buddhism like the major religions of the world who see women as inferior? Please say no."

Well, according to the teachings of the Buddha, women seem to be able to become fully liberated like men. What society does with that is something else. I think you can say just looking across the Asian world—Islam, Hinduism and Buddhism—where you find Buddhism, I think you find much more equality. Women in Buddhist countries are equally doctors, etc. The first prime minister of Sri Lanka was a woman. What was her name? Bandaranaike. But I mean, this is ancient stuff. Patriarchy is embedded in... Come the revolution.

I mean, it comes through the scriptures, which is unfortunate. But I don't see the Buddha... If you read, for instance, the verses left by the elders, both the men and the women, the monks and the nuns, and also lay people, you can see that some of the women were just as fully liberated as the men, and just as much praised and seen as teachers as the monks. The monks sought them out.

So yes, we're stuck with history, I'm afraid. These days, if you look across the *vipassanā* teacher scene, women are probably in the majority. Is that a good sign? Are we returning to matriarchy? Heavens above. I shall leave you with that thought.

I can only hope that my words have been of some assistance. That by your severe devotion to the practice you may be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

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